

Walmart does not pay the women to review their products, it does offer them products for free to review.

Of course, the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) has had something to say about this. So-called “sponsored posts” are considered an extension of traditional advertising and public relations. The FTC revised its guidelines in 2009 for product testimonials and endorsements. Social media marketing can be a sticky issue because of the difficulty of distinguishing between a casual mention of a product and a paid product placement. In order to comply with FTC regulations, bloggers have to disclose that the reviewed product was given to them.

Even casual mentions on my blog of a particular brand of toy that my children were obsessed with actually attracted the attention of a representative of that company. Her job was to google their company name, looking for influential bloggers to do reviews. After her Google search lead her to my blog twice in four months, she contacted me, asking if I’d like to review some of their newest toys. She didn’t have to ask me twice. Free toys? I couldn’t help but have a flashback to the diaper boxes full of toys my children and I had carted home from someone’s garbage years before. This time I didn’t have to have my dignity assaulted or get my hands dirty in the alley. Instead, a small box arrived on my doorstep, and my children dutifully played with the toys while I listened and observed. They weren’t thrilled with the turtle that was included, but they loved the other animals. We were able to keep the toys, and all I had to do was agree to disclose that the company had sent them. It wasn’t a refrigerator or a washer/dryer